
**Unit 1, Option A,
Topic A4: From
Black Death to
Great Revolt:
England, 1348-81**

The focus of this option topic is on the demographic disaster of 1348-49 and its social, economic and political consequences during the reigns of Edward III and his grandson. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of social order and challenge to that order. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, the demographic impact of plague (bullet points 2 and 3) can only be fully understood in terms of the social and economic background addressed in bullet point 1.

The first bullet point relates to social and economic conditions in mid-14th century England before the impact of the great epidemic. Students should have an understanding of the broad economic changes of the previous century, producing over-population, urbanisation and potential crisis. Although questions will not be set on the period prior to 1348, students should be aware of existing signs of economic stagnation and scarce resources and be aware of some of the explanations, for example climate change, soil exhaustion and the impact of war and taxation. Students should have an understanding of some of the salient features of society at this time including the manorial system and serfdom and the concept of bond and free.

The second bullet point relates to the first great outbreak of plague, the Black Death, beginning in southern England in August 1348. The date 1347 in the bullet point refers to its arrival in Italy and 1350 to the year it spread to Scotland. Students should be aware of the spread and nature of the disease, its manifestation as an epidemic and its devastating impact on the English population.

The third bullet point relates to the economic effects of plague and students should be aware of the further outbreaks in 1361, 1368-69 and 1375 and of the estimates made of population loss overall in the period 1348-81. They should understand some of the explanations as to why population recovery was so slow in these years and the impact of population loss on patterns of agriculture, trade and industry.

The fourth bullet point relates to the complex social changes of these years and the effects population loss had on wages and prices and consequently on social hierarchy and living standards. Students should address attempts to peg wages in the Ordinance and Statute of Labourers (1349 and 1351) and attempts to enforce these and manorial rights over the next few decades, and the resentment such attempts caused. The social control attempted in the Sumptuary Law of 1363 should also be understood. Students should study the causes, course and immediate consequences of the Peasants' Revolt of 1381, considering resentment of the attempts to maintain social hierarchy and lower wages as one of the factors in producing this remarkable outburst of disorder and protest.